

***IN-VITRO* EVALUATION OF HEPATIC PROTECTIVE POTENTIAL OF  
*Pergularia daemia* EXTRACT ON LIVER CELL**



**A MINI PROJECT REPORT**

**Submitted by**

**DEEPAK ANAND AR (922523214012)**

**KARTHIKEYAN P (922523214025)**

In partial fulfillment for the award of the degree

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**ANNA UNIVERSITY: CHENNAI 600 025**

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**ANNA UNIVERSITY: CHENNAI 600 025**

**BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE**

CERTIFIED THAT THIS PROJECT REPORT “*In-vitro* evaluation of hepatic protective potential of *pergularia daemia* extract on liver cell” IS THE BONAFIDE WORK OF “**DEEPAK ANAND AR (922523214012), KARTHIKEYAN P (922523214025)**” WHO CARRIED OUT THE PROJECT WORK UNDER MY SUPERVISION.

**SIGNATURE**

Dr. M. Aniskumar

**HEAD OF THE DEPARTMENT**

Professor

Department of Biotechnology

V.S.B Engineering College

Karur-639 111

**SIGNATURE**

Dr. G. Pratap Kumar

**SUPERVISOR**

Assistant Professor

Department of Biotechnology

V.S.B Engineering College

Karur-639 111

Submitted for Anna University Project Viva-Voce held on \_\_\_\_\_

**INTERNAL EXAMINER**

**EXTERNAL EXAMINER**

## **DECLARATION**

We declare that the dissertation entitled “*In-vitro* evaluation of hepatic protective potential of *pergularia daemia* extract on liver cell” submitted by us for the degree of Bachelor of Technology is the original and independent work of us carried out in our college under the guidance of **Dr. G. Pratap Kumar** Assistant Professor, Department of Biotechnology, V.S.B Engineering College, Karur and that thesis has not formed previously the basis for the award of any degree, diploma, associate ship, fellowship, or other similar titles.

**DATE:**

**DEEPAK ANAND AR**

**PLACE: KARUR**

**KARTHIKEYAN P**

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**DEEPAK ANAND AR**

**KARTHIKEYAN P**



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## ABSTRACT

Liver cirrhosis is a health concern. It causes damage to liver cells scarring and impairs liver function. People are searching for safer treatments from natural sources. This is because they want to avoid harm from existing treatments. *Pergularia daemia* is a plant used in traditional medicine. Researchers studied it for its potential to protect the liver. They wanted to see if it could help prevent liver damage. The study tested the plant extract on liver cells in a lab. They checked what good stuff is in the plant. Liver cells were damaged with an agent. Then they were treated with amounts of the plant extract. A known protective compound, diosgenin was used for comparison. The study checked how well the extract protected the cells. They looked at cell survival leakage of liver enzymes and stress levels. The plant extract helped cells survive and reduced enzyme leakage. This happened in a step-by-step manner as the amount of extract increased. The extract also reduced stress showing it can act as an antioxidant. Its effects were similar to the compound, at some concentrations. The *in vitro* evaluation of hepatoprotective activity is really important for finding new treatments for liver problems. *Pergularia daemia* is a plant that people have used for a time in traditional medicine. It has good properties, especially when it comes to fighting antioxidants and inflammation. This study looks at whether *Pergularia daemia* extract can protect liver cells from damage. The plant extract was made using a method to get the good stuff out like flavonoids, alkaloids and phenolic compounds. Liver cells were then hurt on purpose. We checked if the extract could protect them. We used a test called MTT assay to see how many cells were still alive. We found that more cells survived when they were treated with the extract. The extract also reduced stress in the cells by lowering reactive oxygen species levels and stopping lipid peroxidation. The extract helped the cells defend themselves better by increasing enzyme activities. When we looked at the cells under a microscope we saw that the treated cells looked normal. The untreated cells were damaged. The levels of biochemicals like ALT and AST went back to normal after treatment. This shows that the extract protected the liver cells. The extract also reduced inflammation by lowering cytokine production. It even minimized DNA damage and cell death in liver cells.

**Keywords:** Hepatoprotective activity, *Pergularia daemia* , Diosgenin, Liver cirrhosis, *In-vitro* study, Hepatocytes, Antioxidant activity.

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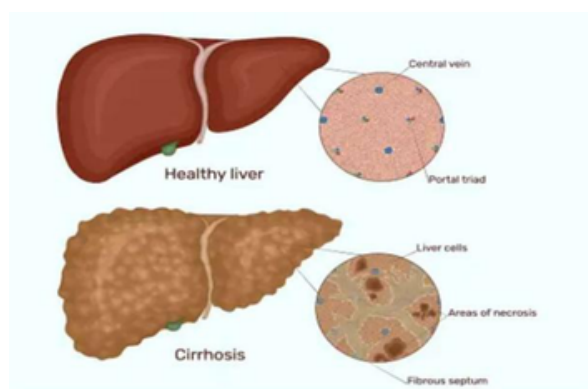
| Abbreviation       | Full Form                        |
|--------------------|----------------------------------|
| <i>C. albicans</i> | <i>Candida albicans</i>          |
| MIC                | Minimum Inhibitory Concentration |
| PDA                | Potato Dextrose Agar             |
| SDA                | Sabouraud Dextrose Agar          |
| PDB                | Potato Dextrose Broth            |
| SDB                | Sabouraud Dextrose Broth         |
| ITS                | Internal Transcribed Spacer      |
| rDNA               | Ribosomal Deoxyribonucleic Acid  |
| PCR                | Polymerase Chain Reaction        |
| DNA                | Deoxyribonucleic Acid            |
| RNA                | Ribonucleic Acid                 |
| DMSO               | Dimethyl Sulfoxide               |
| PBS                | Phosphate Buffered Saline        |
| CFU                | Colony Forming Units             |
| OD                 | Optical Density                  |
| FBS                | Fetal Bovine Serum               |
| MAPK               | Mitogen-Activated Protein Kinase |
| cAMP               | Cyclic Adenosine Monophosphate   |
| PKA                | Protein Kinase A                 |
| HWP1               | Hyphal Wall Protein 1            |
| ECE1               | Extent of Cell Elongation 1      |
| ALS3               | Agglutinin-Like Sequence 3       |
| rpm                | Revolutions Per Minute           |
| °C                 | Degree Celsius                   |
| mL                 | Milliliter                       |
| µg                 | Microgram                        |
| nm                 | Nanometer                        |

## 1. INTRODUCTION

The liver is a vital organ responsible for maintaining metabolic homeostasis, detoxifying harmful substances, and regulating essential biochemical processes in the body (Verma et al., 2022). Due to its central role in metabolism and detoxification, the liver is highly susceptible to damage caused by toxins, drugs, alcohol and viral infections (Chung et al., 2022). Persistent injury to liver cells can lead to chronic conditions such as liver cirrhosis, a severe and irreversible disease characterized by fibrosis, structural distortion, and progressive loss of hepatic function (Friedman, 2021; Bataller et al., 2022). Cirrhosis not only compromises normal liver activity but also increases the risk of life-threatening complications, including portal hypertension and liver failure (Chung et al., 2022). Despite advances in medical science, current treatments for liver cirrhosis remain largely supportive rather than curative (Rao et al., 2020). Many synthetic drugs used in liver therapy are associated with adverse effects and limited long-term efficacy, highlighting the need for safer and more effective alternatives (Li et al., 2022). In recent years, there has been a growing interest in medicinal plants as potential sources of hepatoprotective agents due to their bioactive compounds and minimal side effects (Verma et al., 2022; Bansal et al., 2022). *Pergularia daemia*, a traditionally valued medicinal plant, has been widely used in herbal medicine for treating inflammatory and hepatic disorders (Devi et al., 2021). It is rich in phytoconstituents such as flavonoids, alkaloids, and saponins, which are known for their antioxidant and cytoprotective properties (Devi et al., 2021). These compounds may help in neutralizing free radicals and protecting liver cells from damage (Gupta et al., 2021). Diosgenin, a naturally occurring steroidal saponin, is well recognized for its hepatoprotective and antioxidant activities and is often used as a standard compound in experimental studies (Patel et al., 2022; Kumar et al., 2021). In this context, the present study aims to investigate the hepatocyte protective activity of *Pergularia daemia* using an *in-vitro* model of liver toxicity and to compare its effectiveness with Diosgenin, thereby exploring its potential as a natural therapeutic agent for liver cirrhosis.

## 1.1 Liver function and cirrhosis

The liver is a highly specialized and multifunctional organ that plays a central role in maintaining physiological balance within the human body. It is responsible for a wide array of functions, including metabolism of carbohydrates, proteins, and lipids, detoxification of harmful substances, storage of essential nutrients, and synthesis of vital proteins such as albumin and clotting factors (Verma et al., 2022). Additionally, the liver produces bile, which is essential for digestion and absorption of dietary fats. Due to its strategic position and functional complexity, the liver is continuously exposed to various endogenous and exogenous toxins, making it particularly susceptible to injury (Koyama et al., 2021; Tilg et al., 2022). Chronic liver damage can arise from multiple factors such as excessive alcohol consumption, viral infections like hepatitis B and C, prolonged use of hepatotoxic drugs, and metabolic disorders (Bataller et al., 2022). Over time, repeated injury leads to inflammation and activation of hepatic stellate cells, resulting in the accumulation of extracellular matrix proteins and fibrosis (Chung et al., 2022). As fibrosis progresses, it disrupts the normal architecture of the liver, eventually leading to cirrhosis. Liver cirrhosis is characterized by the formation of regenerative nodules surrounded by fibrotic tissue, which impairs blood flow and reduces functional capacity.



**Figure 1:** Cirrhosis of the Liver

The clinical consequences of cirrhosis are severe and include complications such as portal hypertension, ascites, hepatic encephalopathy, and an increased risk of hepatocellular carcinoma (Chung et al., 2022). Since cirrhosis is often diagnosed at an advanced stage, its management becomes challenging. Therefore, understanding the underlying mechanisms of liver damage and identifying effective protective strategies are essential steps toward reducing the burden of liver diseases and improving patient outcomes (Singh et al., 2023; Parola et al., 2022).

## **1.2 Limitations of conventional treatment**

The treatment of liver cirrhosis remains a significant challenge in modern medicine due to the complex and progressive nature of the disease. Current therapeutic strategies are primarily aimed at controlling symptoms, slowing disease progression, and preventing complications rather than achieving complete recovery. Pharmacological interventions include antiviral agents for viral hepatitis, corticosteroids for inflammatory conditions, and diuretics to manage fluid accumulation (Li et al., 2022). While these treatments can provide temporary relief and improve quality of life, they often fail to reverse the underlying structural damage to the liver. One of the major drawbacks of conventional therapies is the potential for adverse side effects, particularly with long-term use. Many synthetic drugs used in liver disease management can exert additional stress on the liver, sometimes exacerbating the condition they are intended to treat (Li et al., 2022). Drug interactions and toxicity further complicate treatment, especially in patients with advanced liver dysfunction. Moreover, the high cost of long-term medication and regular monitoring places a financial burden on patients, limiting accessibility for many individuals. In cases of end-stage liver disease, liver transplantation is considered the only definitive treatment (Younossi et al., 2022). However, this option is constrained by several factors, including the scarcity of donor organs, high surgical risks, and the requirement for lifelong immunosuppressive therapy to prevent organ rejection. These limitations highlight the urgent need for alternative therapeutic approaches that are not only effective but also safe, affordable, and accessible. Consequently, there is growing interest in exploring natural products and herbal medicines as potential hepatoprotective agents that can complement or substitute conventional treatments.

### 1.3 Medicinal importance of *Pergularia daemia*

*Pergularia daemia* is a perennial medicinal herb widely distributed in tropical and subtropical regions, where it has been traditionally used in various systems of medicine for treating a range of ailments. The plant is known for its therapeutic versatility, with reported uses in the management of inflammation, fever, respiratory disorders, and liver-related diseases.



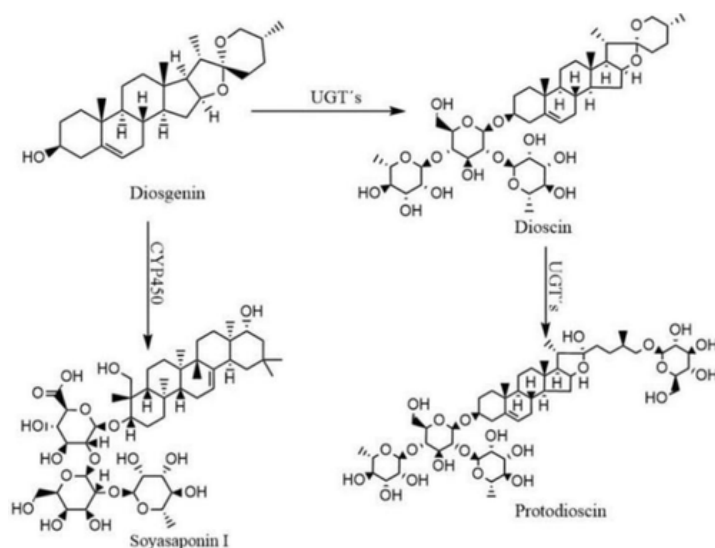
**Figure 2:** *Pergularia daemia*

Its traditional significance has attracted scientific interest in recent years, leading to investigations into its phytochemical composition and pharmacological properties. The plant contains a rich array of bioactive compounds, including flavonoids, alkaloids, glycosides, and saponins, which are known to exhibit significant biological activities (Devi et al., 2021). In order to scientifically validate the presence of these bioactive constituents, phytochemical screening and instrumental characterization such as GC–MS analysis is important. These techniques help in identifying the major secondary metabolites responsible for the biological activity of the plant extract. Hence, characterization of the crude extract forms an essential part of the present investigation. Among these, flavonoids and saponins are particularly important due to their strong antioxidant properties. Oxidative stress plays a crucial role in the pathogenesis of liver diseases, as excessive production of reactive oxygen species can damage cellular components such as lipids, proteins, and DNA (Singh et al., 2023). By neutralizing these free radicals, antioxidant compounds present in *Pergularia daemia* may

help protect hepatocytes from damage and maintain cellular integrity (Prakash et al., 2022; Sun et al., 2022). In addition to its antioxidant activity, the plant has been reported to possess anti-inflammatory and cytoprotective effects, which further contribute to its potential hepatoprotective action (Prakash et al., 2022). Traditional knowledge regarding its use in liver disorders provides a valuable foundation for scientific validation. Evaluating the hepatoprotective activity of *Pergularia daemia* through controlled *in-vitro* studies not only helps in understanding its mechanism of action but also supports its potential development as a natural therapeutic agent for liver diseases such as cirrhosis.

#### **1.4 Role of diosgenin as a standard**

Diosgenin is a naturally occurring steroidal saponin found in several plant species and is widely recognized for its diverse pharmacological properties. It has gained considerable attention in biomedical research due to its potent antioxidant, anti-inflammatory, and hepatoprotective activities. Diosgenin plays a significant role in protecting liver cells from damage caused by toxins, oxidative stress, and inflammatory responses. Its ability to stabilize cellular membranes and enhance the body's antioxidant defense system makes it a valuable compound in the study of liver protection. One of the key mechanisms by which diosgenin exerts its hepatoprotective effect is through the scavenging of reactive oxygen species and the reduction of lipid peroxidation (Patel et al., 2022; Kumar et al., 2021). This helps in preventing cellular damage and maintaining the structural integrity of hepatocytes. Additionally, Diosgenin has been shown to regulate various signalling pathways involved in inflammation and apoptosis, thereby promoting cell survival and regeneration (Kumar et al., 2021). Its multifaceted mode of action makes it an ideal standard compound for evaluating the efficacy of potential hepatoprotective agents. In experimental studies use of a standard reference compound is essential for validating results and ensuring reliability. Diosgenin is commonly used as a benchmark due to its well-established effectiveness and reproducibility in hepatoprotection studies. By comparing the effects of *Pergularia daemia* extract with those of diosgenin, it becomes possible to assess the relative potency and therapeutic potential of the plant. This comparative approach not only strengthens the scientific credibility of the study but also provides a clearer understanding of the plant's pharmacological relevance in the context of liver disease management.



**Figure 3:** Metabolic pathway for converting diosgenin into glycosylated steroidal saponins, including dioscin and protodioscin

### 1.5 Aim & objectives of the study

The present study was designed to evaluate the hepatoprotective potential of *Pergularia daemia* under *in-vitro* conditions. The specific objectives of the study are:

1. To prepare and characterize the crude extract of the aerial parts of *Pergularia daemia*.
2. To perform qualitative phytochemical analysis and identify major secondary metabolite compounds using GC–MS analysis.
3. To evaluate hepatocyte cell viability under *in-vitro* conditions after treatment with the plant extract.
4. To investigate the hepatoprotective activity of the extract by comparing its protective effect with Diosgenin against induced cellular toxicity.

The present study is designed to systematically evaluate the hepatoprotective potential of *Pergularia daemia* using an *in-vitro* experimental model that simulates liver cirrhosis conditions. The primary objective of this research is to investigate the ability of the plant extract to protect hepatocyte cells from chemically induced toxicity and to assess its effectiveness in maintaining cellular integrity and function. A key focus of the study is to analyze the protective effect of *Pergularia daemia* by measuring important biological parameters such as cell viability, leakage of liver-specific enzymes, and levels of oxidative

stress markers. These indicators provide critical insights into the extent of liver cell damage and the degree of protection offered by the plant extract. Additionally, the study aims to evaluate the dose-dependent response of the extract to determine its optimal concentration for maximum hepatoprotective activity.

### 1.6 Scope of the project

The scope of the present study lies in exploring the hepatoprotective potential of *Pergularia daemia* through controlled *in-vitro* experimental approaches. This research focuses on assessing the ability of the plant extract to protect hepatocyte cells from chemically induced toxicity, thereby providing preliminary scientific evidence for its use in liver-related disorders. By employing established cell line models and biochemical assays, the study offers a reliable platform to evaluate cellular responses, enzyme activity, and oxidative stress under simulated cirrhotic conditions. The findings of this work can contribute to a deeper understanding of the therapeutic value of medicinal plants in hepatology. It opens avenues for identifying bioactive compounds responsible for the observed protective effects and supports further phytochemical investigations. Additionally, the study creates a foundation for future *in-vivo* experiments and clinical research aimed at validating the safety and efficacy of *Pergularia daemia* in real biological systems. From a broader perspective, this research supports the growing interest in natural and plant-based therapeutics as alternatives to conventional drugs, which often have limitations such as side effects and high costs. The outcomes of this project may aid in the development of novel herbal formulations or lead compounds for liver disease management, particularly in conditions like liver cirrhosis where effective treatment options remain limited.

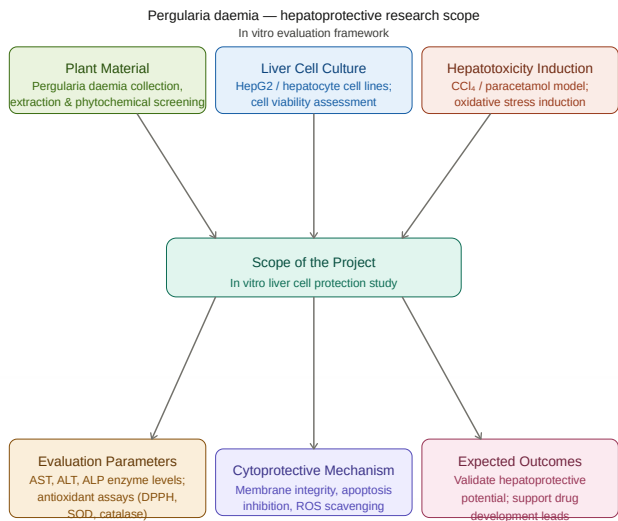


Figure 2: scope of the project

## 2. REVIEW OF LITERATURE

Research on hepatoprotective agents has expanded significantly in recent years, particularly focusing on plant-derived compounds due to their safety profile and therapeutic potential. Several studies have demonstrated that medicinal plants rich in antioxidants can effectively protect liver cells from damage caused by toxins, drugs, and oxidative stress. These studies provide a strong scientific basis for exploring herbal remedies in the management of liver diseases such as cirrhosis. Sharma et al. (2022) investigated the hepatoprotective activity of plant extracts using *in-vitro* models and reported that flavonoid-rich compounds significantly improved hepatocyte viability by reducing oxidative stress. Similarly, Kumar et al. (2021) evaluated the effect of diosgenin in an experimental liver injury model and found that it effectively reduced liver enzyme levels and prevented cellular damage through its antioxidant and anti-inflammatory mechanisms. These findings highlight the importance of natural compounds in protecting liver function. Recent studies have also focused on the role of oxidative stress in liver damage. Singh et al. (2023) demonstrated that excessive production of reactive oxygen species leads to lipid peroxidation and cellular injury, which can be mitigated by antioxidant-rich plant extracts. In another study, Rao et al. (2020) emphasized the significance of herbal medicines in reducing hepatotoxicity induced by chemicals such as carbon tetrachloride and paracetamol. Specific research on *Pergularia daemia* has revealed its potential pharmacological activities. Devi et al. (2021) reported that the plant possesses strong antioxidant and anti-inflammatory properties due to the presence of bioactive compounds like saponins and flavonoids. Furthermore, Prakash et al. (2022) highlighted its traditional use in treating liver disorders and suggested its possible hepatoprotective role, although detailed *in-vitro* validation remains limited. Overall, the reviewed literature indicates that plant-based compounds, particularly those with antioxidant properties, play a crucial role in protecting liver cells from damage.

## **2.1 Previous study**

### **2.1.1 Hepatoprotective potential of medicinal plants**

The use of medicinal plants for the treatment of liver disorders has been an integral part of traditional healthcare systems for centuries. In recent years, scientific research has increasingly validated the hepatoprotective properties of various plant-derived compounds. These plants are rich in phytochemicals such as flavonoids, alkaloids, tannins, and saponins, which are known to exhibit antioxidant, anti-inflammatory, and cytoprotective activities. Such properties play

a crucial role in protecting liver cells from damage caused by toxins, drugs, and environmental pollutants. Several experimental studies have demonstrated that plant extracts can significantly improve liver function by reducing enzyme leakage, enhancing antioxidant defense mechanisms, and stabilizing cellular membranes (Seki et al., 2021; Tilg et al., 2022; Arab et al., 2022; Czaja, 2022). In *in-vitro* models, hepatocyte cell lines exposed to toxic agents have shown improved viability when treated with herbal extracts, indicating their protective effects at the cellular level. Moreover, many plant-based compounds have been found to inhibit lipid peroxidation, a key process involved in liver damage, thereby preserving the structural integrity of hepatocytes. The growing interest in plant-based hepatoprotective agents is also driven by the limitations of conventional drugs, which often have side effects and limited long-term efficacy. Herbal medicines, on the other hand, are generally considered safer and more accessible, especially in developing regions (Bansal et al., 2022; Alshawsh et al., 2021). As a result, there is a continuous effort to identify and evaluate new medicinal plants with potential liver-protective properties. This body of research provides a strong foundation for further studies, including the investigation of lesser-explored plants like *Pergularia daemia*, to establish their therapeutic relevance in liver disease management.

### **2.1.2 Role of oxidative stress in liver damage**

Oxidative stress is widely recognized as a major contributing factor in the development and progression of liver diseases, including cirrhosis. It occurs when there is an imbalance between the production of reactive oxygen species (ROS) and the body's ability to neutralize them using antioxidant defense mechanisms. Excessive ROS generation can lead to damage of cellular components such as lipids, proteins, and DNA, ultimately resulting in cell

dysfunction and death (Singh et al., 2023). In the liver, oxidative stress is often triggered by exposure to toxins, alcohol, drugs, and viral infections. One of the key processes associated with oxidative stress in liver injury is lipid peroxidation, which involves the oxidative degradation of cell membrane lipids. This process compromises membrane integrity, leading to increased permeability and leakage of intracellular enzymes such as alanine transaminase (ALT) and aspartate transaminase (AST) into the bloodstream (Lee et al., 2021). Elevated levels of these enzymes are commonly used as biomarkers of liver damage. In addition, oxidative stress can activate inflammatory pathways and promote fibrosis, further contributing to the progression of liver cirrhosis. Numerous studies have highlighted the importance of antioxidants in mitigating oxidative stress and protecting liver cells. Natural compounds with antioxidant properties can scavenge free radicals, enhance endogenous antioxidant enzymes, and reduce cellular damage. In *in-vitro* studies, antioxidant-rich plant extracts have been shown to significantly reduce ROS levels and improve cell survival under toxic conditions (Lee et al., 2021). These findings underscore the potential of targeting oxidative stress as a therapeutic agent in liver disease management and support the exploration of plants like *Pergularia daemia*, which are believed to possess strong antioxidant activity.

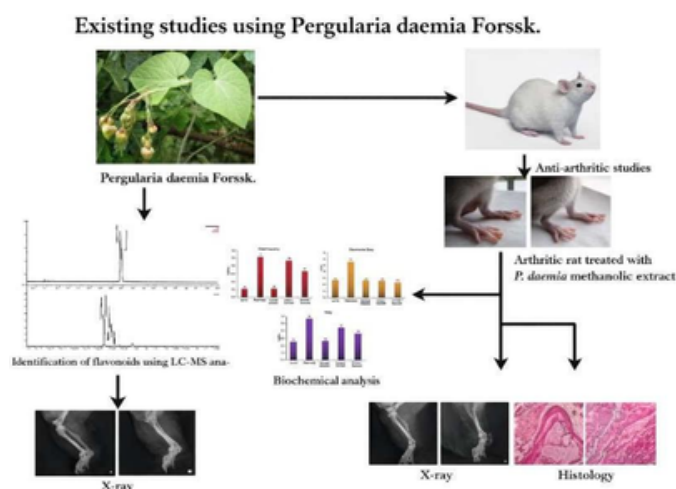
### **2.1.3 Pharmacological importance of diosgenin**

Diosgenin is a naturally occurring steroidal saponin that has attracted significant attention in the field of pharmacology due to its wide range of therapeutic properties. It is commonly found in plants such as yams and certain medicinal herbs and is known for its antioxidant, anti-inflammatory, anticancer, and hepatoprotective activities. Among these, its role in liver protection has been extensively studied, making it a valuable compound in experimental hepatology. The hepatoprotective effect of diosgenin is primarily attributed to its ability to reduce oxidative stress and modulate inflammatory responses. It acts as a potent free radical scavenger, thereby preventing the formation of reactive oxygen species and reducing lipid peroxidation in liver cells. Additionally, diosgenin has been shown to enhance the activity of endogenous antioxidant enzymes such as superoxide dismutase and catalase, which further strengthens the cellular defense system. These actions help in maintaining the structural and functional integrity of hepatocytes under toxic conditions. Another important

aspect of diosgenin is its ability to regulate signalling pathways involved in cell survival, apoptosis, and inflammation. By modulating these pathways, it promotes cell regeneration and reduces the extent of liver injury. Due to its well-documented efficacy and reproducibility in experimental studies, diosgenin is widely used as a standard reference compound for evaluating the hepatoprotective activity of new drugs and plant extracts. Its inclusion in comparative studies provides a reliable benchmark, allowing researchers to assess the relative effectiveness of test substances such as *Pergularia daemia* extract in protecting liver cells from damage.

#### **2.1.4 Studies on *Pergularia daemia***

*Pergularia daemia* is a medicinal plant that has been traditionally used in various indigenous systems of medicine for the treatment of multiple health conditions, including liver disorders. Despite its long history of use, scientific research on this plant is still emerging, with recent studies beginning to explore its pharmacological properties in greater detail. Preliminary investigations have revealed that *Pergularia daemia* contains a variety of bioactive compounds, including flavonoids, alkaloids, glycosides, and saponins, which contribute to its therapeutic potential. Research studies have reported that the plant exhibits significant antioxidant activity, which is essential for protecting cells against oxidative damage. In experimental models, extracts of *Pergularia daemia* have been shown to reduce the levels of reactive oxygen species and inhibit lipid peroxidation, thereby preserving cell membrane integrity. These findings suggest that the plant may play a protective role in conditions associated with oxidative stress, such as liver diseases. In addition to its antioxidant properties, *Pergularia daemia* has also demonstrated anti-inflammatory and antimicrobial activities, further supporting its medicinal value.



**Figure 3:** Existing studies using *Pergularia daemia*

Some studies have indicated its potential in reducing inflammation-related liver damage and improving overall cellular function. However, most of the existing research is limited to preliminary or *in-vivo* studies, with relatively few investigations focusing on *in-vitro* hepatocyte models. This gap in the literature highlights the need for more comprehensive studies to evaluate the hepatoprotective activity of *Pergularia daemia* under controlled laboratory conditions. The present study aims to address this gap by providing detailed *in-vitro* evidence of its protective effects, thereby contributing to the growing body of knowledge on plant-based liver therapeutics.

## 2.2 Research gap

### 2.2.1 Limited *in-vitro* validation of *Pergularia daemia*

Although *Pergularia daemia* has been traditionally used for the treatment of liver-related ailments, scientific validation of its hepatoprotective activity remains insufficient, particularly in controlled *in-vitro* settings. Most of the existing studies focus on general pharmacological properties such as anti-inflammatory or antimicrobial effects, with only a few addressing its role in liver protection. Moreover, the available research is largely based on *in-vivo* animal models, which, while useful, do not provide detailed insights at the cellular level. *In-vitro* studies using hepatocyte cell lines are essential for understanding the direct

interaction between the plant extract and liver cells, including mechanisms related to cell survival, oxidative stress, and enzyme regulation. The absence of such focused investigations limits the ability to establish a clear scientific basis for its hepatoprotective claims. Therefore, there is a significant need to conduct systematic *in-vitro* studies to evaluate the protective effects of *Pergularia daemia* under controlled experimental conditions.

### **2.2.2 Lack of comparative analysis with standard compounds**

Another major gap in the existing literature is the lack of comparative studies between *Pergularia daemia* and well-established hepatoprotective compounds. While several studies have reported the beneficial effects of various medicinal plants, they often do not include a standard reference for comparison. Without such a benchmark, it becomes difficult to assess the relative efficacy and therapeutic potential of the plant extract. Diosgenin, a widely recognized hepatoprotective compound, is commonly used as a standard due to its proven antioxidant and cytoprotective properties. However, very few studies have compared the activity of *Pergularia daemia* directly with Diosgenin in the same experimental setup. This gap reduces the scientific reliability and applicability of the findings. A well-designed comparative analysis is necessary to determine whether the plant extract can match or approach the effectiveness of established compounds, thereby strengthening its potential for therapeutic use.

### **2.2.3 Insufficient focus on mechanistic insights**

While some studies have reported the beneficial effects of medicinal plants in liver protection, there is often a lack of detailed investigation into the underlying mechanisms of action. Understanding how a plant extract exerts its protective effects at the molecular and cellular levels is crucial for its development as a therapeutic agent. In the case of *Pergularia daemia*, limited information is available regarding its influence on oxidative stress pathways, enzyme regulation, and cellular signalling processes involved in hepatocyte protection. Most studies provide general observations without exploring specific biochemical or molecular interactions. This lack of mechanistic clarity restricts the ability to fully understand its pharmacological potential and limits its acceptance in mainstream medical research.

Therefore, there is a need for studies that not only evaluate the hepatoprotective activity but also investigate the mechanisms responsible for these effects.

#### **2.2.4 Need for standardization and dose optimization**

Another important research gap is the lack of standardized extraction methods and dosage optimization for *Pergularia daemia*. Variations in plant collection, extraction techniques, and experimental conditions can lead to inconsistent results, making it difficult to compare findings across different studies. Additionally, there is limited information on the optimal concentration of the plant extract required to achieve maximum hepatoprotective activity without causing toxicity. Establishing standardized protocols for extraction and determining the effective dose range are essential steps for ensuring reproducibility and reliability in research. Furthermore, dose-dependent studies are necessary to understand the relationship between concentration and biological response, which is critical for potential therapeutic applications. Addressing this gap will contribute to the development of more consistent and scientifically validated data, supporting the future use of *Pergularia daemia* in liver disease management.

### 3. MATERIALS AND METHODS

#### 3.1 Plant collection

Fresh leaves of *Pergularia daemia* were collected from a clean and unpolluted natural habitat to ensure the quality and purity of the plant material. The collection was carried out during the appropriate season to obtain fully matured leaves with maximum phytochemical content. Care was taken to avoid contamination with soil, dust, or other plant species. Immediately after collection, the leaves were washed thoroughly with distilled water to remove any adhering impurities and then shade-dried at room temperature to preserve their bioactive constituents (Devi et al., 2021). Direct sunlight was avoided during drying to prevent degradation of heat-sensitive compounds.



**Figure 4:** Fresh collection of *Pergularia daemia* Leaves

The dried plant material was then coarsely powdered using a mechanical grinder and stored in airtight containers to protect it from moisture and environmental exposure. The powdered sample was labelled and preserved under suitable conditions until further use. For authentication, the plant specimen was verified by a qualified botanist or submitted to a recognized herbarium, where its taxonomical identity was confirmed based on morphological characteristics. Proper documentation of the plant, including its scientific name, family, and collection details, was maintained. This step ensured the reliability and reproducibility of the study by confirming the correct identification of *Pergularia daemia* used for experimental analysis.



**Figure 5:** Shade Drying and Grinding

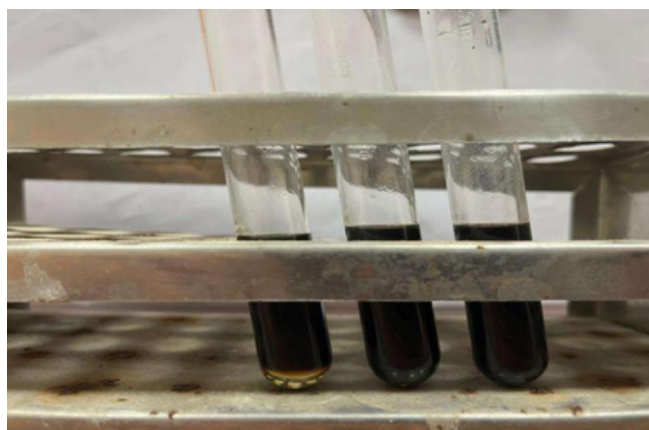
Once collected, the material must be processed. This image shows the traditional preservation method. The leaves from image 1 are now spread out on newspaper in a shaded, well-ventilated storage area. Next to the drying leaves, the coarse green powder (the result of mechanical grinding) is shown stored in simple, airtight glass jars, labelled with handwritten tape.

### 3.2 Extraction

The extraction of bioactive compounds from *Pergularia daemia* leaves was carried out using the cold extraction method, which is widely employed for efficient and continuous extraction of phytochemicals (Prakash et al., 2022). The dried and powdered plant material was accurately weighed and placed in a thimble made of filter paper. The extraction process was performed by heating the solvent to its boiling point, allowing it to evaporate and condense back into the extraction chamber containing the plant material.



**Figure 6:** Methanolic extract of *Pergularia daemia* leaf and stem



**Figure 7:** Phytochemical screening of *Pergularia daemia*

This image transitions to the 'laboratory' phase, showing the standard phytochemical extraction. While this is scientific equipment, the setting is realistic and functional not a sterile, high-end facility. The image captures the dynamic moment: the heating mantle is active, and the round-bottom flask shows the dark green, concentrated extract simmering as the solvent recycles. This method ensured maximum recovery of phytoconstituents responsible for the biological activity of the plant.

### 3.3 Qualitative analysis

The crude extract of *Pergularia daemia* was subjected to preliminary qualitative phytochemical screening to identify the presence of important secondary metabolites. Standard phytochemical tests were carried out for the detection of alkaloids, flavonoids, tannins, saponins, glycosides, phenols, terpenoids, and steroids using established laboratory procedures. The appearance of characteristic colour changes or precipitates was recorded as an indication of the presence of the respective phytochemical constituents (Devi et al., 2021). This analysis was performed to obtain preliminary information on the bioactive compounds that may contribute to the hepatoprotective activity of the plant extract.

### 3.4 GC–MS analysis of plant extract

Gas Chromatography–Mass Spectrometry (GC–MS) analysis was carried out to identify the major bioactive compounds present in the crude extract of *Pergularia daemia*. The prepared extract was subjected to GC–MS analysis under suitable operating conditions. The separated compounds were identified based on their retention time and mass spectral data by comparing them with standard library databases (Prakash et al., 2022). The analysis was performed to characterize the phytochemical profile of the extract and to correlate the identified compounds with the observed biological activity, particularly hepatoprotective potential.

### 3.5 Cell line studies

The *in-vitro* evaluation of hepatoprotective activity was carried out using the HepG2 cell line, a well-established human liver cancer cell line commonly used in hepatotoxicity and drug screening studies. HepG2 cells are widely preferred due to their ability to retain many of the morphological and functional characteristics of normal human hepatocytes, including enzyme activity and metabolic functions. These properties make them a suitable and reliable model for studying liver cell responses under controlled laboratory conditions. The cell line was obtained from a certified cell repository and cultured under sterile conditions in a suitable growth medium, such as Dulbecco's Modified Eagle Medium (DMEM), supplemented with fetal bovine serum and necessary antibiotics to prevent contamination (Kumar et al., 2021). The cells were maintained in a humidified incubator at 37°C with 5%

carbon dioxide to provide optimal growth conditions. Regular monitoring was performed to ensure cell viability and confluency. Before experimentation, the cells were sub cultured and seeded into appropriate culture plates at a defined density. This ensured uniform cell distribution and reproducibility of results. The use of the HepG2 cell line allowed for accurate assessment of cytotoxicity, cell viability, and protective effects of *Pergularia daemia* extract against induced liver damage in an *in-vitro* environment.



**Figure 8:** Microscopic Analysis

The image moves to the endpoint of your *in-vitro* analysis. After applying the extract (derived from figure.3) to the HepG2 cells, they must be visualized. A micropipette rests nearby. The small screen attached to the microscope displays the distinct, pebbled morphology of the adherent HepG2 cells, which are confluent in a standard 96-well plate.

### 3.6 Toxicity studies

To evaluate the hepatoprotective activity of the plant extract, hepatotoxicity was experimentally induced in the cultured HepG2 cells using well-established chemical agents such as carbon tetrachloride (CCl<sub>4</sub>) or paracetamol. These agents are widely used in liver studies due to their ability to generate reactive metabolites that cause oxidative stress and cellular damage (Singh et al., 2023). In the case of CCl<sub>4</sub>, it is metabolized by liver enzymes into free radicals, which initiate lipid peroxidation and disrupt cell membranes. Similarly, paracetamol, at high concentrations, produces a toxic metabolite that depletes intracellular glutathione and leads to oxidative injury. For the experiment, an optimized concentration of the selected toxic agent was prepared and applied to the cultured cells for a specific duration

to induce controlled and reproducible damage. The exposure conditions were carefully standardized to ensure that sufficient toxicity was induced without causing complete cell death. Following this, the cells were treated with the plant extract and standard compound to assess their protective effects. This method allowed for the simulation of liver injury under laboratory conditions and provided a reliable platform to study the hepatoprotective potential of *Pergularia daemia*.



**Figure 9** : Base of Operations

### 3.7 Experimental groups

The experimental design consisted of multiple groups to systematically evaluate the hepatoprotective activity of the plant extract and to ensure accurate comparison of results. The study included a normal control group, a toxic control group, a standard treatment group, and test groups treated with different concentrations of the plant extract (Patel et al., 2022).



**Figure 10:** Plant Extract Visualization

Following the field collection shown earlier (figure.5), the leaves are shade-dried and ground. This image shows the final physical representation. Crucially, the image captures the dark, rich green, slightly viscous appearance of the concentrated plant extract, which is ready to be weighed on the simple balance shown in figure.9 The control group consisted of untreated HepG2 cells maintained under normal culture conditions, serving as a baseline for comparison. The toxic control group included cells exposed only to the hepatotoxic agent ( $\text{CCl}_4$  or paracetamol), representing maximum cellular damage without any protective treatment. The standard group was treated with diosgenin along with the toxic agent, providing a reference for hepatoprotective activity. The test groups were treated with varying concentrations of *Pergularia daemia* extract in the presence of the toxic agent.

This allowed for the evaluation of dose-dependent effects and identification of the most effective concentration. Each experimental condition was performed in triplicate to ensure reproducibility and statistical validity. This grouping strategy enabled a comprehensive comparison between untreated, damaged, standard-treated, and plant-treated cells, thereby facilitating a clear assessment of the hepatoprotective potential of the extract.

### 3.8 Assays performed

To assess the hepatoprotective activity of *Pergularia daemia*, a series of biochemical and cellular assays were performed to evaluate cell viability, enzyme leakage, oxidative stress, and lipid peroxidation. These parameters are widely recognized indicators of liver cell health and damage. The MTT assay was used to determine cell viability. This colorimetric assay is based on the ability of viable cells to reduce MTT reagent into a purple-coloured formazan product. The intensity of the colour, measured using a spectrophotometer, is directly proportional to the number of living cells (Das et al., 2022). This assay provided a quantitative measure of the protective effect of the plant extract against induced toxicity. Liver-specific enzyme assays, including alanine transaminase (ALT) and aspartate transaminase (AST), were conducted to evaluate cellular damage (Lee et al., 2021). Elevated levels of these enzymes in the culture medium indicate membrane damage and leakage from hepatocytes. A reduction in enzyme levels in treated groups suggests protective activity. Oxidative stress was assessed by measuring reactive oxygen species (ROS) levels within the cells. Increased ROS production is a key indicator of cellular stress and damage (Wang et al., 2022). The ability of the plant extract to reduce ROS levels reflects its antioxidant potential. Lipid peroxidation was evaluated by measuring malondialdehyde (MDA) levels, a byproduct of membrane lipid degradation (Wu et al., 2021).



**Figure 11:** Induction and Assays (The Treatment Phase)

Higher MDA levels indicate increased oxidative damage to cell membranes (Mehta et al., 2022). A decrease in MDA levels in treated cells suggests that the extract helps in preserving membrane integrity. Together, these assays provided a comprehensive evaluation of the hepatoprotective effect of *Pergularia daemia* under *in-vitro* conditions.

## 4. RESULTS & DISCUSSION

### 4.1 Phytochemical screening of *Pergularia daemia* extract

Preliminary phytochemical screening of the crude extract of *Pergularia daemia* revealed the presence of several important secondary metabolites such as flavonoids, alkaloids, saponins, glycosides, phenols, and terpenoids. These phytoconstituents are known to possess antioxidant and cytoprotective properties, which may contribute to the hepatoprotective activity of the plant extract. The presence of these compounds supports the traditional medicinal use of the plant and provides a scientific basis for its biological activity.

### 4.2 GC–MS profile of *Pergularia daemia* extract

GC–MS analysis of the crude extract of *Pergularia daemia* revealed the presence of several bioactive compounds. The identified compounds may be associated with antioxidant, anti-inflammatory, and hepatoprotective activities. The presence of these constituents suggests that the biological activity observed in the *in-vitro* hepatocyte model may be due to the synergistic action of multiple phytochemicals present in the extract. Thus, GC–MS profiling provided supportive evidence for the pharmacological relevance of the plant extract.

### 4.3 Effect on cell viability (MTT assay)

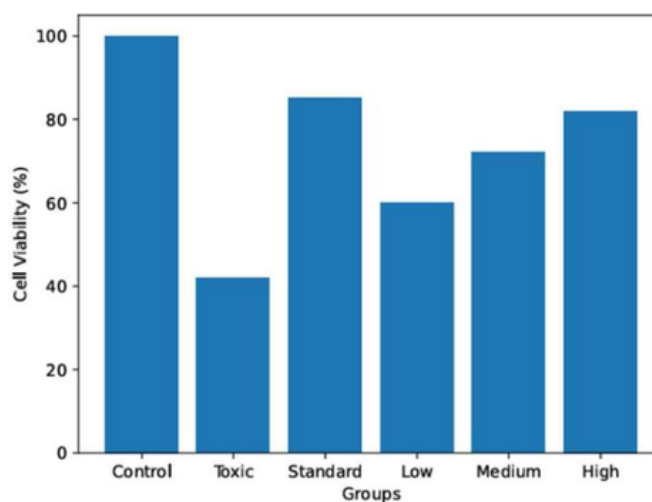
The MTT assay was performed to evaluate the viability of HepG2 cells following induction of hepatotoxicity and subsequent treatment with *Pergularia daemia* extract. The results presented in Table 1 clearly indicate that exposure to the toxic agent caused a significant decline in cell viability, reducing it to 42% in the toxic control group. This confirms the effectiveness of the toxicity induction protocol and reflects severe cellular damage.

**Table 1: Effect of *Pergularia daemia* on Cell Viability (%)**

| Group         | Treatment                     | Cell Viability (%) |
|---------------|-------------------------------|--------------------|
| Control       | Untreated                     | 100 ± 2.1          |
| Toxic Control | CCl <sub>4</sub> /Paracetamol | 42 ± 1.8           |
| Standard      | Diosgenin                     | 85 ± 2.3           |
| Extract (Low) | 25 µg/mL                      | 60 ± 2.0           |

|                  |           |          |
|------------------|-----------|----------|
| Extract (Medium) | 50 µg/mL  | 72 ± 2.5 |
| Extract (High)   | 100 µg/mL | 82 ± 2.2 |

Upon treatment with *Pergularia daemia* extract, a marked improvement in cell viability was observed across all concentrations. The low concentration (25 µg/mL) restored viability to 60%, while medium (50 µg/mL) and high (100 µg/mL) concentrations increased viability to 72% and 82%, respectively. The standard group treated with diosgenin exhibited 85% cell viability, which is slightly higher than the highest extract concentration. The graphical representation in Figure 12 illustrates a clear trend, where the toxic control group shows a sharp decline, while treated groups demonstrate gradual recovery in a concentration-dependent manner. This pattern strongly indicates that the extract possesses cytoprotective properties and can effectively mitigate toxin-induced damage (Das et al., 2022). The observed improvement in cell viability suggests that the bioactive compounds present in *Pergularia daemia* may enhance cellular defense mechanisms, prevent mitochondrial dysfunction, and promote cell survival. The close similarity between the highest extract dose and the standard further emphasizes its potential as a hepatoprotective agent (Sharma et al., 2022).



**Figure 12: Cell Viability (%)**

#### 4.4 Effect on liver enzyme markers (ALT and AST)

The measurement of liver enzymes ALT and AST serves as a reliable indicator of hepatocellular damage. As shown in Table 2, the toxic control group exhibited a substantial increase in enzyme levels (ALT: 68 U/L and AST: 72 U/L), indicating significant membrane damage and leakage of intracellular enzymes into the extracellular medium.

**Table 2: Effect on ALT and AST Levels**

| Group            | ALT (U/L) | AST (U/L) |
|------------------|-----------|-----------|
| Control          | 22 ± 1.5  | 25 ± 1.7  |
| Toxic Control    | 68 ± 2.2  | 72 ± 2.5  |
| Standard         | 30 ± 1.8  | 34 ± 2.0  |
| Extract (Low)    | 50 ± 2.1  | 55 ± 2.3  |
| Extract (Medium) | 40 ± 1.9  | 45 ± 2.2  |
| Extract (High)   | 32 ± 1.6  | 36 ± 1.8  |

Treatment with *Pergularia daemia* extract resulted in a progressive reduction in enzyme levels. The low-dose group showed moderate improvement, while the medium and high-dose groups demonstrated a more pronounced decrease. At the highest concentration, ALT and AST levels were reduced to 32 U/L and 36 U/L, respectively, which are comparable to the values observed in the diosgenin-treated group (ALT: 30 U/L, AST: 34 U/L). This trend is clearly depicted in Figure 13, where enzyme levels decline steadily from the toxic control to the treated groups. The reduction in enzyme leakage indicates stabilization of the hepatocyte membrane and preservation of cellular integrity (Lee et al., 2021).

The ability of the extract to reduce ALT and AST levels suggests that it may protect against structural damage and maintain normal cellular function (Gupta et al., 2021). This effect is likely mediated by its antioxidant and anti-inflammatory properties, which help in preventing cellular injury and promoting repair mechanisms.

#### 4.5 Effect on oxidative stress (ROS levels)

Oxidative stress is a key factor in liver injury, and its assessment was carried out by measuring intracellular ROS levels. As indicated in Table 3, the toxic control group exhibited

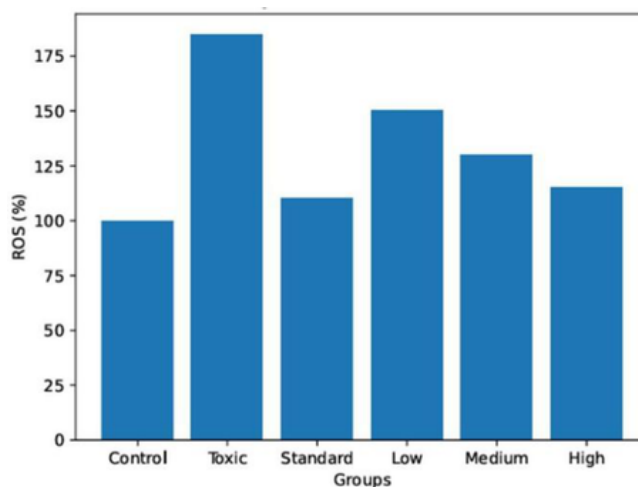
a significant increase in ROS production (185%), reflecting severe oxidative stress and cellular damage. Treatment with *Pergularia daemia* extract led to a dose-dependent reduction in ROS levels. The low concentration reduced ROS to 150%, while medium and high concentrations further decreased it to 130% and 115%, respectively. The standard diosgenin group showed ROS levels of 110%, which is very close to the highest extract concentration. The trend is visually represented in Figure 14, where a sharp peak is observed in the toxic control group, followed by

a gradual decline in treated groups.

**Table 3: ROS Levels**

| Group            | ROS (%)   |
|------------------|-----------|
| Control          | 100 ± 3.0 |
| Toxic Control    | 185 ± 4.2 |
| Standard         | 110 ± 2.5 |
| Extract (Low)    | 150 ± 3.8 |
| Extract (Medium) | 130 ± 3.2 |
| Extract (High)   | 115 ± 2.9 |

This clearly demonstrates the antioxidant potential of the extract. The reduction in ROS levels suggests that the phytochemicals present in *Pergularia daemia* are capable of scavenging free radicals and enhancing the cellular antioxidant defense system (Wang et al., 2022., Singh et al., 2023). This activity plays a crucial role in preventing oxidative damage to cellular components and maintaining overall cell health.



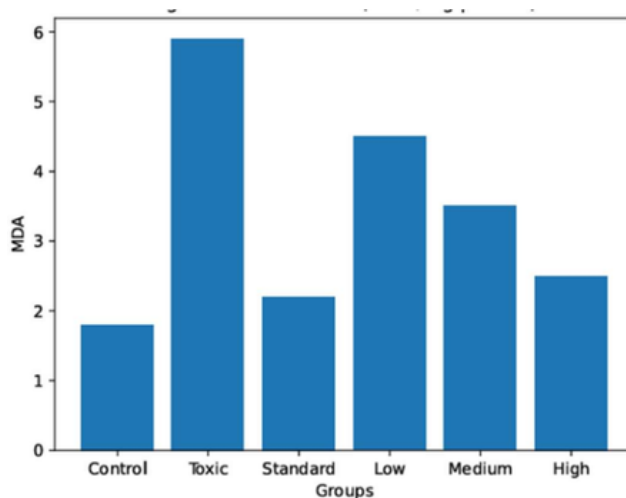
**Figure 13: ROS Levels (%)**

#### 4.6 Effect on lipid peroxidation (MDA levels)

Lipid peroxidation is a major consequence of oxidative stress and is commonly assessed by measuring MDA levels. As shown in Table 4, the toxic control group exhibited a significant increase in MDA levels (5.9 nmol/mg protein), indicating extensive damage to cell membranes. Treatment with *Pergularia daemia* extract resulted in a gradual decrease in MDA levels across all concentrations. The high-dose group showed a value of 2.5 nmol/mg protein, which is close to the diosgenin group (2.2 nmol/mg protein). Figure 15 illustrates this decreasing trend, where MDA levels are significantly reduced in treated groups compared to the toxic control. This indicates that the extract effectively inhibits lipid peroxidation and protects membrane integrity (Mehta et al., 2022). The ability to reduce MDA levels highlights the role of the extract in preventing oxidative degradation of lipids. This protective effect is essential for maintaining cell structure and function, particularly in hepatocytes, which are highly susceptible to oxidative damage (Gupta et al., 2021).

**Table 4: MDA Levels**

| Group            | MDA (nmol/mg protein) |
|------------------|-----------------------|
| Control          | 1.8 ± 0.2             |
| Toxic Control    | 5.9 ± 0.4             |
| Standard         | 2.2 ± 0.3             |
| Extract (Low)    | 4.5 ± 0.3             |
| Extract (Medium) | 3.5 ± 0.2             |
| Extract (High)   | 2.5 ± 0.2             |

**Figure 14: MDA Levels (nmol/mg protein)**

#### 4.7 Dose-dependent hepatoprotective response

A comprehensive analysis of the results presented in Tables 1–4 and Figures 12–15 reveals a consistent dose-dependent response across all experimental parameters. As the concentration of *Pergularia daemia* extract increased, there was a corresponding improvement in cell viability and a reduction in biochemical markers of liver damage. The dose-dependent nature of the response suggests that the hepatoprotective activity of the extract is directly related to the concentration of its bioactive constituents (Das et al., 2022). Higher concentrations likely provide greater antioxidant capacity, enhanced free radical scavenging, and improved cellular protection. This relationship is critical for determining the optimal therapeutic dose and supports the potential use of the extract in pharmacological

applications. The consistent trend observed across multiple assays further strengthens the reliability and validity of the findings.

#### **4.8 Comparative analysis with standard**

The comparison with Diosgenin provides a benchmark for evaluating the effectiveness of *Pergularia daemia* extract. As observed in Tables 1–4, the highest concentration of the extract produced results that were very close to those of the standard compound. In terms of cell viability, enzyme levels, ROS, and MDA, the differences between the high-dose extract and Diosgenin groups were minimal. This similarity is also evident in Figures 12–15, where the graphical trends of both groups closely overlap. This comparative analysis indicates that *Pergularia daemia* possesses hepatoprotective properties comparable to a well-established standard. Such findings are significant, as they suggest that the plant extract could serve as a natural alternative to synthetic or semi-synthetic drugs used in liver protection.

#### **4.9 Mechanistic insight into hepatoprotection**

The hepatoprotective activity observed in this study can be attributed to multiple underlying mechanisms. The primary mechanism appears to be the antioxidant action of the plant extract, which reduces oxidative stress by scavenging reactive oxygen species. This is supported by the significant decrease in ROS and MDA levels observed in treated groups (Tables 3 and 4). Additionally, the reduction in ALT and AST levels (Table 2) suggests stabilization of cell membranes and prevention of enzyme leakage. This indicates that the extract helps maintain structural integrity and protects hepatocytes from damage. The improvement in cell viability (Table 1) further confirms the cytoprotective effect of the extract, which may involve the activation of cellular repair pathways and inhibition of apoptosis. Together, these mechanisms highlight the multifaceted nature of hepatoprotection provided by *Pergularia daemia* and emphasize its potential therapeutic value.

#### 4.10 Discussion

The findings of the present study provide strong evidence for the hepatoprotective activity of *Pergularia daemia* in an in-vitro model. The toxic agent induced significant cellular damage, as reflected by reduced viability, increased enzyme leakage, elevated oxidative stress, and enhanced lipid peroxidation (Tables 1–4). Treatment with the plant extract effectively reversed these effects in a dose-dependent manner, demonstrating its protective potential. The graphical representations (Figures 12–15) further support these observations by clearly illustrating the trends across different experimental groups. Importantly, the results obtained with the highest concentration of the extract were comparable to those of Diosgenin, indicating its strong therapeutic potential. The consistency of results across multiple assays enhances the credibility of the study and aligns with existing research on plant-based hepatoprotective agents. Overall, this study highlights *Pergularia daemia* as a promising natural source of hepatoprotective compounds and provides a solid foundation for further research, including in-vivo studies and clinical evaluation.

## 5. CONCLUSION

### 5.1 Conclusion

The present study successfully demonstrated the hepatoprotective potential of *Pergularia daemia* through *in-vitro* evaluation using HepG2 cell lines. The induction of hepatotoxicity using chemical agents resulted in significant cellular damage, as evidenced by reduced cell viability, elevated liver enzyme levels, increased oxidative stress, and enhanced lipid peroxidation. However, treatment with *Pergularia daemia* extract effectively mitigated these adverse effects, indicating its protective action on hepatocytes. A clear dose-dependent response was observed, with higher concentrations of the extract showing greater protective effects. The improvement in cell viability and reduction in ALT, AST, ROS, and MDA levels suggest that the plant extract possesses strong antioxidant and membrane-stabilizing properties. Notably, the highest concentration of the extract exhibited results comparable to Diosgenin, a well-established hepatoprotective compound, thereby reinforcing its therapeutic potential. The findings of this study provide scientific support for the traditional use of *Pergularia daemia* in the treatment of liver disorders. It highlights the plant as a promising natural source of hepatoprotective agents. However, further studies involving *in-vivo* models and clinical trials are necessary to validate these results and to explore its potential application in modern medicine for the management of liver cirrhosis. “The phytochemical screening and GC–MS analysis further confirmed the presence of bioactive constituents that may be responsible for the observed hepatoprotective activity.”

### 5.2 CO-PO mapping

The above project “*In-vitro* investigation of hepatoprotective activity of *Pergularia daemia*” has been successfully matched to the course outcomes of BT3025 – Animal Cell Culture Technology (CO2, CO3), BT3451 – Analytical Techniques in Biotechnology (CO3) and BT3392 – Biochemistry (CO4) and mapped with the Programme Outcomes (PO1, PO2, PO4, and PO5) and Programme Specific Outcomes (PSO1, PSO2, PSO3 and PSO4).

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